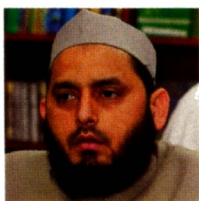


SANJAY SONKAR



RUFFLED UP:
Mannan
(centre) with
clerics



"This nikah is a cheap publicity stunt."

MAULANA KHALID RASHID FRINGI MAHALI, PRESIDENT, AIUC



"Anti-Islam forces are instigating Muslim women to break tradition and create confusion."

MAULANA ABDUL MANNAN, CHIEF, ALL INDIA COUNCIL OF IMAMS

The fallout was that Maulana Fazl-ur-Rahman, the shahi imam of Lucknow's Tilewali Masjid, and Maulana Abdul Mannan, the chief of the All India Council of Imams, held meetings and warned Muslims against the "Satanic conspiracy". Addressing a meeting of clerics, Mannan said the role of males and females has been defined in Islam. "Disruptive and anti-Islam forces are instigating Muslim women to break Islamic tradition and create confusion," he said. But Naish made it clear that she had made an attempt to demolish the patriarchal mindset within the Muslim society.

Recently Morocco, a Muslim country, appointed women as preachers who could also perform the functions of an imam in a mosque, but stopped short of allowing a woman to lead the prayers. This explains why ulemas, mainly representing the Sunni sect, are irate over the way Naish married Naeem. Under the glare of television cameras, in a hotel overflowing with male and female guests, Naish sat without veil and had a half-bare head while Naeem was without a cap. The nikah was conducted in English, contrary to the practice that the ceremony must be held in Arabic. Besides, the second important part of nikah—recitation of Quranic verses and Khutba (sermon)—was also missing. Moreover, the couple belongs to the Sunni sect while the qazi is a Shia. This was not all. Naish had prepared her own *nikah-nama* (marriage contract) in which both bride and groom took an oath that he

would not divorce her in one go and that she has the equal right to divorce him.

The ulemas are still to recover from the shock. Maulana Khalid Rashid Fringi Mahali, president of the All India Ulema Council (AIUC) and member of the All India Muslim Personal Law Board, dismissed the exercise as a "cheap publicity stunt". Some even termed it a "Zionist conspiracy". "During the 1,400 years of Islam, no woman has conducted nikah. This is the result of a conspiracy of Mossad and communal forces," said Fazl-ur-Rahman. All India Muslim Women Personal Law Board chief Shaista Ambar, who recently introduced a separate pro-women *nikahnama*, said Naish should not get a licence to disrupt the socio-religious order under the cover of uplifting Muslim women. "Who can take away the role of the male qazi, and priests in the church, while conducting weddings?" she questioned.

However Shia cleric Kalbe Jawwad feels there is "nothing wrong in a woman conducting a nikah if she has the same knowledge as her male counterpart". Naish and Naeem are, however, unfazed by attacks from the most powerful sections of Muslim society. "This is a message I want to send to young girls, and a protest against the subjugation of women," Naish declared. Whether it remains an isolated act or encourages other Muslim women to fight for greater equality is too early to predict but the credibility of the couple and the woman qazi surely represents a serious challenge to the established order. ■